

Good Girls Grow Tough

Questions that today's women ask before marriage

HOW CLOSE DO YOU WANT TO LIVE TO YOUR PARENTS' HOUSE?

DO YOU EXPECT ME TO DO ALL OF THE COOKING AND HOUSEWORK?

WOULD YOU INSIST ON HAVING A JOINT BANK ACCOUNT?

IF I AM MOVED TO ANOTHER CITY, WOULD YOU WANT ME TO QUIT MY JOB?

WOULD YOU EXPECT ME TO STOP WORKING ONCE WE HAVE CHILDREN?*

ANSHUMAN ANARKAT, 33

Insurance Executive, AHMEDABAD

His banker father and homemaker mother taught him to be broad-minded. Anarkat thinks that there's nothing tangible that he wants out of a lifemate—not fair complexion, beauty, degrees, matching caste or horoscope. Even age does not figure on his list. All he wants is a normal, grounded partner, with whom his chemistry and values will gel. Trendy clothes don't make a woman modern, he believes. Today's woman is one who knows how to flow with time.

"I am looking for a girl between age 26 and 34. I would feel more comfortable with a woman in that age group."



pendent and honest. Dilip wants "a good-minded, loving woman," who will understand him. Kumar is looking for a simple girl who would understand his needs and "know how to make a happy home".

Bangalore throws up the most balanced statistics. Here, the fetish for fair skin stands at a safe midpoint between demanding Rajasthan and easy-going Gujarat, with 41 per cent saying "it doesn't matter". When asked, "Will

you shift base if your partner needs to?" Bangalore men take it easy between the open-minded Ahmedabadi and the apprehensive Kolkatan. Over 45 per cent in Bangalore believe in meeting up via each other's families, sandwiched between two extremes: Rajasthan and Kolkata. On caste, Bangalore is in the middle between flexible Delhi and traditional Kerala. On preference for joint families, Bangalore is chilled out at 49 per cent, between Gujarat and Kerala.

No wonder, the city has an even-handed take on men. "Changing lifestyles have changed men's attitude," says sociologist Ram Kumar of Bangalore University. "They no longer think of a wife primarily as a cook." Alka Susan, who made *She Spoke*, a documentary on gender politics, finds the modern urban Indian male less judgemental. "The boy, in most urban Indian households, seems to have found a voice," says theatre personality, Smita Mani, whose work often critiques Indian masculinity. "For a starter, men don't ask prospective brides to serve them tea. They take them out to Cafe Coffee Day, instead," she jests. But how deep is this

change? "I want to know how many men will want to jointly live with their wife's family, volunteer to quit his job if needs be, or choose to go along if the wife gets a transfer," she asks. Susan feels intrigued by the self-centred image of the modern woman. "A lot of men, I think, are living with hackneyed stereotypes of the selfless Indian woman—who goes without food, puts husband and children first." Kumar feels, with the harsh winds of global socio-economic shifts this is an area that will become unrecognisable in the future.

The modern man has never had more choice of life-partners. But also never more trouble dealing with the multitude of options that today's woman presents him with. Men have shed a lot of those old limiting signposts in choosing a life-mate—beauty and age, caste and community, joint family and domestic goddesses—that haunted their fathers. The new demands for compatibility tell the new story of masculinity. To find a mate, men are ready to work harder than ever before for they are aware that marriage today is a partnership in every which way.

with Nirmala Ravindran

36%

OF MEN ARE OPEN TO THE IDEA OF MARRYING A GIRL WITH A DISABILITY

*Source: BharatMatrimony, "Trend Report on the Attitude of Modern Indian Men & their Partner Preference", 2009

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